Thucydides reports. But another way to make access simpler is to use a dedicated web server for the living documentation.

12.4.2 Publishing living documentation to a dedicated web server

Some teams choose to publish living documentation to a dedicated web server. Any web server will do, because the reports are just static HTML. This way, team members don't need to log on to the build server or find the right build job; they can access the documentation simply and directly.

This approach requires a little more initial configuration to deploy the reports, but most CI servers let you deploy files to a remote server easily enough. For example, Jenkins has several plugins that make it easy to deploy files across FTP, SFTP, and so on.

It can be useful to store previous versions of the living documentation for future reference. A common strategy is to publish the latest living documentation on a dedicated web server, and to store older versions on the build server.

12.5 Faster automated acceptance criteria

As you've seen, automated acceptance criteria are an excellent way to provide rich and meaningful feedback about the state of a project. And compared to manual tests, automated acceptance criteria are certainly fast. But in terms of build automation, automated acceptance tests (along with performance tests and load tests) are often among the slowest of the automated tests you're likely to run. The value of feedback is proportional to the speed with which you receive it, so faster feedback is always preferable.

When automated acceptance tests take too long to run, the whole development and release process suffers. A full release process that takes 15 to 30 minutes, for example, provides reasonably fast feedback for developers and makes it easier to streamline the release process and get new features or bug fixes deployed as quickly as they're implemented. But if your full test suite takes three hours to run, developers will often have to wait until the following day to get feedback about their changes, and same-day releases of changes and bug fixes becomes much harder.

In this section, we'll look at a few ways you can speed up your automated acceptance tests, and as a result speed up your delivery process.

12.5.1 Running parallel acceptance tests within your automated build

One way to speed up tests is to configure the acceptance criteria to run in parallel directly within the automated build. Modern machines with multicore processors have plenty of processing power that can be harnessed to accelerate your test suite. Exactly how you do this varies greatly depending on what BDD toolset you're using, and different tools have different levels of support for parallel processing.

If you're implementing your automated acceptance criteria using JBehave and Thucydides with Maven, for example, you can use the parallel execution capabilities that come with the Maven JUnit test runner Surefire (http://maven.apache.org/surefire/maven-surefire-plugin/) used to execute the JBehave scenarios. In figure 12.8, you can see a typical project structure using JBehave and Thucydides.